L'envoi

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37829236.

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General Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by EmperorNorton150

Summary

Catra and Adora finally talk. About the past, about the present, and about the future.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"There! There it is again!"

"Yeah, yeah, I see it."

The sky over Bright Moon was flickering again, twisting and folding in on itself, ripples spreading out across the bright blue dome of the atmosphere as incomprehensible amounts of energy was brought to bear against the fabric of reality itself. Catra and Adora watched it from the highest tower of the castle, legs dangling down over the rooftops and turrets below as the sky over them *stretched*—and snapped back into place with a final flurry of colors. Catra hissed.

"It's getting worse. Even just in the last few weeks." she said.

"Yup."

"How long do you think we have?"

"Before Horde Prime breaks through? Castaspella says…….months at least. Maybe even a year or two. But not more than that." Catra nodded.

"The Horde's ready" she said softly. "Thirty-two battle groups with organic support elements, twenty-six combat air wings, fifty-eight independent brigades, eight battle squadrons and screening units, full compliments of auxiliaries…….we're going to defend our planet."

"We're ready too" said Adora. "We've got seven Princesses and an army of sorcerers and…….a whole lot of guys with swords and spears and whatnot." She could hear the hammering in the castle forges all night now, as the blacksmiths tried to make enough weapons for the volunteers flooding in to join up. People had known abstractly about the threat of Prime for over a year now, of course. But nothing could prepare you for that moment when you first looked up and saw a hole in the sky. He

was coming. Everybody knew it. It was only a matter of time. "I just hope it's enough……" she murmured.

"It will be" said Catra.

"How can you be sure?" asked Adora.

"We've got She-Ra, haven't we?" Adora turned to look at Catra, who just raised an eyebrow and grinned. "What?" she said. "Are you suggesting that She-Ra *isn't* the invincible, all-powerful divinely-inspired guardian of Etheria? Are you implying that you *aren't* the Holy One, Avatar of the Lost Stars, chosen champion of the people and—ouch!" Adora had elbowed her in the side.

"Shut up" she said as Catra chuckled, but she was smiling too. "You're awfully cheery today."

"Why shouldn't I be?" Catra leaned back on her elbows, shaking out her hair across the stone tiles of the rooftop. "Shadow Weaver's back in a prison cell, I've been able to purge the Horde of traitors and spies, King Hiss of the Snake-Men is suing for peace…….except for the looming apocalypse and all, things are going *quite* well, thank you very much."

"What's next on your agenda then, O Glorious Conqueror?"

"Oh, this and that. I'm thinking of setting up a consultative council."

"A what?"

"You know, an elected council of advisors from the towns and villages under Horde rule." Adora turned to stare.

"Um. Why?" Catra started counting on her claws.

"One, it'll let me get an idea of what most of my subjects actually think about my policies, two, I can play it off

against the Command Council of Force Captains and keep everyone so tied up fighting each other they won't have time to bother me, and three, I wanna see sparkles' face when she realizes I'm less of a tyrant than she is." She smirked, and Adora rolled her eyes.

"Fine, whatever. Just leave me out of it, ok?"

"Whatever you say princess. So. Um. How have *you* been?" Adora shrugged.

"Good, I guess? Everybody's still getting used to having Micah back. I mean, it's amazing! It's just really *weird*. For all of us, but for Glimmer and Angella especially, y'know? There's not really a protocol for this kind of situation."

"I *still* can't believe that crazy old guy is king."

"Catra!"

"Whaaaat. He's not *my* king. I can call him crazy if I wanna."

"He's really nice" insisted Adora. "It's just—weird."

"Sparkles freaking out?" asked Catra quietly.

"Uh. A little bit?"

"Thought so" muttered Catra. "Tell her she can talk to me if she wants to, ok?"

"Awwww—"

"Shut up!

"But you and Glimmer are—"

"I said shut up!" Catra's ears flattened against her head and she scowled up at Adora, who grinned back but wisely didn't respond. After a moment she said instead

"I talked to Light Hope. About the Heart of Etheria."

"Oh?"

"I couldn't get a straight answer out of her! I can tell she knows something but she won't tell me anything except that I need to keep training so I can balance the planet 'when the time comes'!"

"Ah. So what do *you* think?"

"I think……I think Shadow Weaver was telling the truth. I just don't know what to do about the fact that I—maybe?—possibly?—have the power to annihilate planets or whatever!"

"Try not to annihilate this one? *Don't* look at me like that Adora, you've been turning into a magic princess goddess for years now, I don't see what's so much worse about this." Adora shook her head.

"Aren't you worried?" she asked.

"Of course I'm worried" snaped Catra. "But we can't do anything about it right now so there's no use getting upset. When the time comes you'll figure it out and we'll either blow up Horde Prime or punch Light Hope in the face."

"She's a hologram Catra. I don't think you can punch holograms in the face."

"We'll figure it out. We always do." Adora felt something soft and warm fill her chest. She glanced at Catra, who was lying almost fully recumbent on the roof now, eyes closed as she soaked in the moonlight. She thought it might be the most beautiful thing she'd ever seen. "I can feel you smiling at me" growled the Generalissimo of the Horde. "Cut it out."

Silence fell, the companionable silence of two people who know each other well enough that they don't need to speak. Birds sang in the distant trees of the Whispering Woods, the voices of cooks

and servants and soldiers drifted up from the castle below. It wasn't quite like being back on top of their tower in the Fright Zone but—it was close. There was that special feeling of secrecy, the sense that the whole world was spinning around beneath your feet but it couldn't touch you. She didn't want to spoil it. But she knew she had to. Finally, after a long while, Adora said

"Can we talk?"

"We've *been* talking" said Catra without opening her eyes.

"I mean…….about us."

"Oh" said Catra flatly. "Do we have to?"

"Well, Glimmer said she wouldn't get us down from here if we didn't *so*….."

"Traitor" muttered Catra. Silence fell again for a long moment before, in a very small voice, she said "Adora? I'm…….I'm sorry." Adora's hands clenched on the edge of the roof, and her breath caught in her throat. Carefully, very carefully, she replied.

"For what?"

"For……..everything that happened after Thaymor. For hurting you and your—your friends. For trying to destroy your kingdom. For throwing you off a cliff that one time. For everything I said. For not listening to you."

"It—it worked out alright."

"Yeah. But I wasn't thinking about any of *this* back then." Catra waved her hand in a vague circle. "I just wanted….." her voice trailed off. "I wanted you to hurt as much as I did."

"Catra….."

"No, just listen to me, ok? When you left—you ran away and became a princess and found new friends and became a hero and everybody loved you and you saved the world—you left me with Shadow Weaver. By *myself*." Her fur bristled, and she scrubbed at her eyes with one hand. "It was—I was so scared and so lonely and so angry and the only person in the *world* who would listen to me had *abandoned* me because a *talking sword* told her to. Can you understand that?"

"You could've come with me. I wanted you to come with me! Angella would have taken you in and Bow and Glimmer would've loved you and—"

"If *you* asked them to" Catra said coldly.

"What?" Adora blinked, and Catra's tail lashed.

"I would have been your pet. They would have accepted me because of *you*, and only because of you. The Horde's my home. I might've hated it, but it had a place for me. I wasn't going to run off to some castle and be your loyal sidekick until you got bored again and kicked me out!"

"Do you really think I would do that?" asked Adora, eyes wide. Catra sighed.

"No" she said. "I don't. But…..Adora, I don't want to live on your charity. Or Glimmer's, or Queen Angella's, generous as I'm sure it would be. The Horde is my *home*, for better or worse." Adora nodded.

"What changed?" she asked.

"Hmmm?"

"Why did you stop—just wanting to hurt me?" Catra snorted.

"Oh. A girl can only wallow in self-pity for so long. Hordak promoted me to Force Captain and Lonnie and Scorpia

and the others were relying on me and I needed to protect them from Shadow Weaver and the more I worked the more I realized that…….I had something to offer. I could……accomplish something, maybe even something great. Something by myself, without your help. No offense."

"None taken."

"And then after I won…….after I took over the Horde I started to realize…….well, what's it like to have responsibilities to something bigger than yourself. It made me…….understand you a little better. Why you felt you had to do what you had to do. Adora drummed her feet against the side of the tower, watching the moons begin to sink down towards the western horizon.

"I'm sorry too."

"For what?"

"For……leaving you. For hurting you. For not being there when you needed me. Catra, I—you meant *so much* to me. You were my best friend in the whole world. I never, *ever* wanted to cause you pain."

"I know that" said Catra. "But…..you still did."

"I know" said Adora, staring down at the ground. "I just…..I just don't know what else I could have done! I couldn't stay with the Horde, not after I knew what they were really doing."

"That's what I don't understand" said Catra. "How did you not know? I knew that Hordak was a monster as long as I can remember, because if he *wasn't* than he wouldn't let Shadow Weaver do whatever she wanted to me. And if they lying to us about *that* then they were probably lying about bringing 'peace' and 'freedom' to Etheria, yes? I mean, you're not *actually* stupid Adora."

"Thanks" said Adora drily. "I guess I just……I mean, I should've noticed, you're right but……I was *happy* growing up. I didn't realize how awful so much of it had been until I left."

"Well, yeah, of course, you were always Weaver's favorite—"

"No" broke in Adora. "I mean, *yes*, but that's not why. I was happy because…..I was always with you." Catra didn't say anything and Adora didn't dare look at her, but after a minute she felt the other girl silently grip her hand and squeeze it.

"I should have listened to you more" said Adora. "You were right—when you said I was treating you like a sidekick or something. I took you for granted."

"Maybe it was all for the best" said Catra at last. Her claws scratched circles aimlessly in the stone. "Maybe we needed some time apart. We wouldn't be the people we are today if we'd kept being good little cadets. I don't think that's a bad thing."

"Oh"

"Need*ed*"

"Oh!" Catra rolled her eyes.

"So" she said finally. "What do we do now?"

"I don't know" replied Adora. "We're not……we're not who we used to be. We're not kids any more, and we can't just go back to the way it was before. We have separate lives now, we have responsibilities. But……I want you be part of my life again."

"It was easier hating you" Catra said. Moonlight glittered on her epaulets and the frogging on her uniform as she shifted uneasily. "At least I knew where we stood. Now……it's good to talk to you again, it *really* is, but…..it still hurts sometimes. Being with you."

"I'm sorry" whispered Adora. Catra shrugged.

"Not your fault. But it reminds me of—of what it was like. Before. And it *hurts*." Her tail lashed and she clenched her fists tightly.

"If you don't want to see me again, I understand" said Adora. "I wanna do whatever makes you happy. But I want to you to know—I love you, ok? You matter *so much* to me and—and you always will. Whatever happens. Please remember that."

"Adora. What…..do you mean by 'love'?" Catra said very slowly. It was one of those moments—like when she and Adora had faced each other at Thaymor, bombs bursting around them, the screams of the wounded echoing, and neither one aware of anything except each other. It was a moment in which life was going to go *one* way or *another*, and you didn't know which until it was too late.

"Ummm, it's, uhh, well, it's like when you *like* somebody or something but a lot more so than usual and—" Catra's ears flicked.

"No, no, I know what the *word* means you idiot. But exactly what did *you* mean by it?"

"Oh. Um. Uh. Well." Catra saw movement out of the corner of her eye, and felt something warm and soft brush against her cheek. She turned to Adora and raised an eyebrow, ignoring the sudden hammering of her heartbeat.

"Did you just kiss me?" she asked. Adora turned bright red.

"Um. Maybe?" she squeaked. Catra sighed.

"You dork. That was pathetic. Let me show you—" A minute later, they broke apart again, panting for breath. Adora had the *stupidest* grin on her face, and Catra was *buzzing*, deep in her chest. "I love you too, dummy" she murmured.

"Wow" said Adora. Catra snickered.

"You really *are* a moron—hey!" Adora had grabbed her and pulled her down on top of her. There were a few movements of laughing struggle before they ended up curled around each other, Catra's head lying on Adora's chest, her tail looped around her leg.

"So how long have you—" asked Adora.

"Forever. You?"

"Same."

"Then how come you never—"

"I was afraid—what if you didn't—"

"How could you think I would—" Catra broke off, laughing. "Wow. This just makes everything feel a *lot* stupider, doesn't it?" Adora looked sheepish, or at least as sheepish as someone grinning like a maniac can look. Then her eyes flashed, and for just a second, Catra realized what it must be like to be an Etherian villager looking up and seeing She-Ra, sword brandished, defiant against all enemies.

"That was the past. It's time to think about the future."

"It's not gonna be easy" warned Catra. "I still have to govern half the planet and about two-thirds of my Force Captains would have frothing *fits* if they saw us like this." She paused. "Hey, actually, can you drop by my next Command Council meeting?"

"Shush" said Adora, poking Catra in the side. "I still have to protect Etheria from evil and 'balance the planet'. And, umm, I don't know how Queen Angella or the rest of the Princess Alliance will react to this but I doubt it'll be good. Not to mention the whole Horde Prime situation."

"Do you care?"

"No" said Adora simply. "This—I've wanted this always. I'm not giving it up." Catra kissed her again, shivering with amazement that she was *actually really doing this for real*. Part of her was still convinced this a dream.

"Then we'll figure it out" she said. "Together. Whatever happens."

"You promise?" asked Adora.

"I promise" said Catra.

There wasn't anything else that needed to be said after that. They lay cuddled on the roof together, arms and legs wrapped around each other, listening to each other's breathing, feeling the warmth of each other's skin.

Adora realized she was crying, tears trickling gently down her cheek. She couldn't wipe them away without dislodging the weight of the Supreme Commander of the Horde draped over her limbs. She wouldn't dream of it. She had barely dared to hope that she would ever *see* Catra again after Thaymor. Then she'd hoped just to talk to her, to spend time with her, to try and rebuild even just a fragment of what they'd had and lost. To have *this?* To have everything she'd always dreamed of in the innermost depths of her heart? It seemed almost *too* good to be true, like she was stealing good fortune from someone more deserving. She shoved those thoughts aside. Eventually they'd go back to the real world and She-Ra would pick up her sword and all duties. This time was *hers* and hers alone.

Catra was always on edge. As long as she could remember, she'd been a bundle of fear and anger and anxiety, a churning mess of emotions that she couldn't understand or cope with. But right now, she was calm. It was a feeling so unfamiliar to be almost unnerving, a curious serenity flowing out from her center. But then again, this was the day she'd been waiting for her whole life.

She had dreamed of this day since she was a child, never really letting herself believe it would come. And now…….it had. She didn't know how to deal with that. Part of her, the part that had led her to victory over Shadow Weaver and Hordak and so many other opponents, that had catapulted to leadership of the Horde and rule over half of Etheria, was still busy calculating, plotting out the implications and consequences of this. Another part, the part that had driven her awake in the middle of so many nights drenched in sweat, was raging in incoherent fury that Adora *dared to pretend that she could still after all this time*—but for once Catra found it easy to ignore them both, to lock both voices in a little box and tune them out. This was what she wanted. She wasn't going to let go, no matter what.

Overhead, the sky shivered and pulsed, the energy of a thousand stars captured and funneled and forged into a weapon capable of piercing the veil of space-time hammering slowly through the dimensional barrier. The Future was drilling its way inexorably towards them, bringing fleets of ships beyond count and legions of troops beyond number and the all-encompassing Will of Horde Prime. They ignored it. It wasn't here yet. And when it arrived, they'd deal with it. Together.

Always together.

End Notes

- I have had, almost since the beginning of this series, a very rough plan of where I wanted it to end, with Horde Prime arriving and a huge invasion and climactic battle. But the more I wrote, the less certain I was that I was ever going to be able to get to that point. There were just too many unresolved issues with it, from a plot perspective and from a 'my writing abilities' standpoint. I'm still thinking about possible continuations of this series, because I love writing it, but I don't know for sure when and if that's going to be happen. So think of this as a 'soft ending'. I wanted to give this series some kind of emotional conclusion, and I didn't want to just leave it hanging here forever. I may well return to this at some point! But I can't make any promises, and enough people have been reading these that I didn't want to just abandon them.

- On that note, thank you so much to everyone who's left comments and kudos on these stories!!! It really means so much to me. The first story in this series was my first real attempt at fanfic, and the amazing encouragement and feedback I received has really inspired me to keep writing. This series might be over (for now?) but I want to return to my New Era series when I get the chance, and I have a few ideas for stand-alone stories kicking around, so stick around if you've enjoyed these. And thank you again. :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!